25 Winning Doubles Tactics



TENNIS TRIBE

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The Author



Will Boucek is the Founder & CEO of The Tennis Tribe. He has played and coached tennis for over two decades including in college. Currently a strategy analyst for ATP & WTA tour players and coaches, as well as Division I College Programs, Will helps people become smarter doubles players. As a player himself, Will tests the latest tennis gear from Wilson, Babolat, Head, Prince, and other tennis brands. He lives in Fort Worth, Texas where he regularly competes in USTA leagues & tournaments.

The Tennis Tribe

The Tennis Tribe is dedicated to helping people become better at tennis. With a focus on doubles strategies, tactics, and tips ***we believe that getting better at tennis shouldn't require dozens of hours of court time every month.*** By teaching our players to outsmart their opponents, we help people win more matches every single week. Over 100,000 people use The Tennis Tribe each month to improve their game and review the best tennis gear.

About These Tactics

All the tactics below can be broken down into primary patterns and secondary patterns. Don't worry about the names of each tactic as much as the process of execution and the scenarios where they are best utilized.

- **Primary patterns** are tactics you'll use the majority of the time. Like a fastball in baseball, primary patterns are your "go-to tactics."

- **Secondary patterns** are used less often, but are still crucial to keep the opponents off-balance. To stick with the baseball analogy, these are like the changeup or curveball. Use these in specific situations, or when you think the opponent won't expect it.

SERVE TEAM TACTICS

Below are some of my favorite serve tactics. You'll notice some of them have more to do with the server, while others are a combination of serving to the right spot and the net player moving.

1. Pressure Point Power Play

What is it? A flat power serve to the middle of the box.

How to execute? The server should hit a flat serve in the middle of the box, right at the returner. Aim for the middle to improve your make percentage. The net player should pinch towards the middle to volley any weak returns.

When to use it? This is a great secondary tactic to use on tight game points - up 40-30 or ad in. This is especially effective for players who don't hit a lot of flat or body serves since the returner hasn't seen it.

2. R.E.M. (Return Error Manufacturer)

What is it? A wide serve combined with a big fake by the net player.

How to execute? In the deuce or ad court, hit your serve out wide, preferably with spin. As the ball crosses the net, the server's partner should be moving towards the middle net strap. If you're quick, you should cross the center service line. When the returner begins their swing, recover towards the doubles alley to get a volley or, more likely, take credit for a return error.

- **Deuce Court:** You'll have a backhand volley in the doubles alley so it's best to move early so you can fully recover.
- **Ad Court:** You have a forehand volley in the doubles alley so you can move a bit later. The forehand volley has more reach and is more consistent.

When to use it? Low risk, but important points - 15-15, 30-15, 40-15, 30-30, 40-30, deuce, ad in. Sometimes when you run this, you will get beat down the alley or the return might go over the middle as you move away from it. In both cases, you might miss a volley. So this may not be worth using when down a break point depending on your situation.

3. The I-Formation

What is it? The server lines up near the center service mark. The server's partner crouches down on the center service line, only a few feet from the net strap.

How to execute? This can be a primary pattern with tons of options. The net player can move in either direction, and the server can use any type of serve depending on the situation. Often when using this in the ad court, the net player can stay in the middle and give up the short angle to their left since most returner's won't be able to make that with consistency.

When to use it? When the opponent is in a rhythm returning crosscourt this is a great way to throw them off. Also, if they are returning with depth you can use the I-formation to make them return down the line, shortening the court for them.

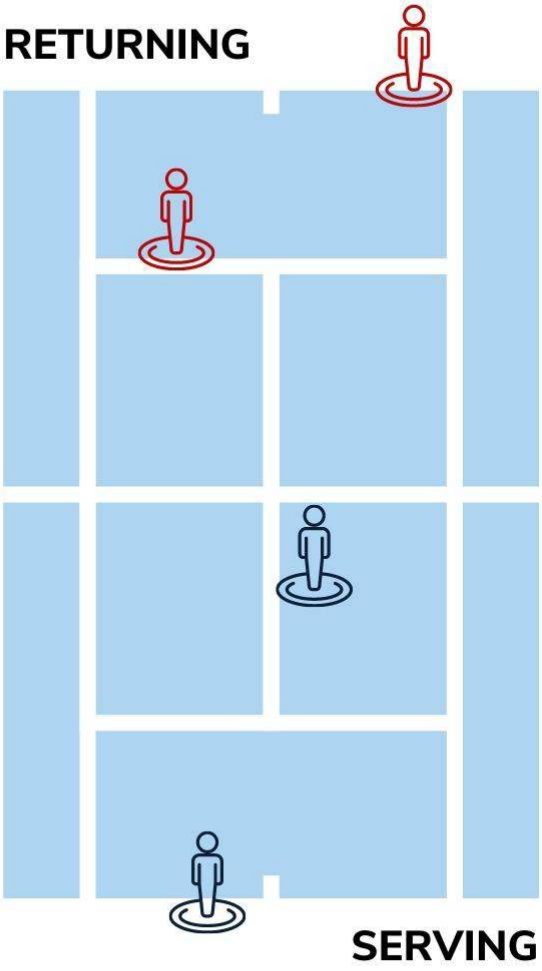


4. The Offset I-Formation

What is it? Think in between regular and I-formation.

How to execute? The net player should read the returner here. Typically players will hit returns across their body, so T serves might be more likely to come down the line, while wide serves usually come crosscourt. As soon as you know which stroke they have, you can either recover more towards the doubles alley, or stay pinched towards the middle.

When to use it? Similar to the I-formation, this is a great tactic to use when the opponent is in a rhythm returning crosscourt or with depth. By narrowing the crosscourt window, you're making them choose between a more difficult crosscourt return than before and the risky down the line return.

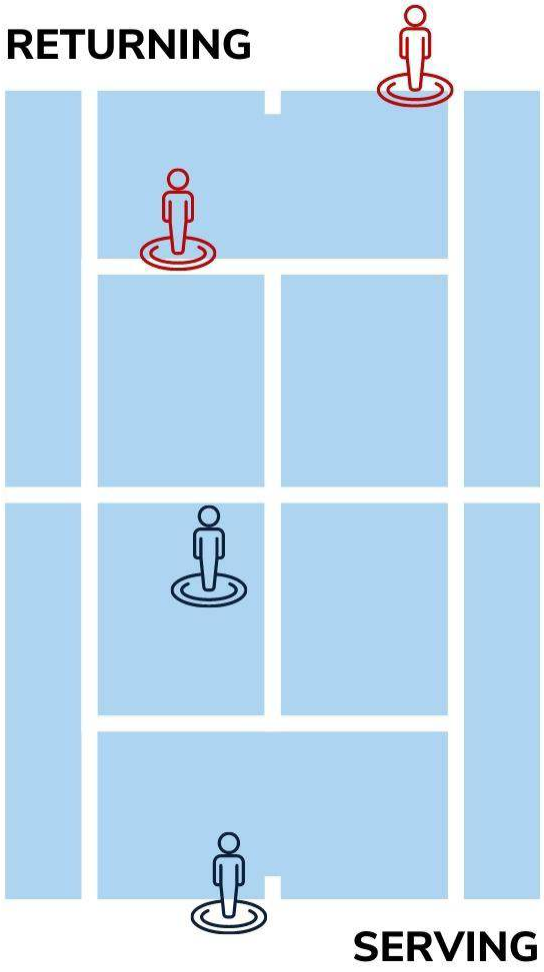


5. Australian Formation

What is it? The server and their partner stand on the same side of the court.

How to execute? Typically it's best to serve wide or into the body in this formation so the server can get to the next ball. If you serve down the T and the opponent returns across their body, down the singles line, for example, the ball will be moving away from the server making it difficult to run down. When you serve wide, they have to return back towards the middle of the court. The net player should stay on the same side as the server.

When to use it? This is a great tactic at the club level if you have a weak groundstroke that you need to hide. It's often used in the ad court so the server has a forehand as their next shot. It's also a good tactic if you're in a bad crosscourt matchup, or the opponent is in a rhythm returning crosscourt.



6. Serve & Volley

What is it? The server immediately moves forward to the net after the serve.

How to execute? When you serve and volley, you want to get your ball toss out into the court so your body's momentum is already towards the net after the serve. Typically slower and/or wide serves are best so you have more time to get forward. After the serve, prepare for a half volley around the service line. The server's partner should pinch the middle or fake.

When to use it? If the opponent is returning with depth or you are getting stuck in crosscourt rallies that you won't win.

7. Serve +1 & Volley

What is it? The server moves forward to the net after the first shot after the serve, called the serve +1.

How to execute? Hit your serve +1 with depth crosscourt. Higher over the net or slower is better to buy yourself time to get forward. A slice will also work. The server's partner will pinch or fake.

When to use it? This is a great tactic if you're not comfortable with a traditional serve and volley, and are getting stuck in crosscourt rallies that you won't win.



Doubles Only Tennis Podcast: 3.5 Case Study

"Your style and advice worked where hours of private lessons with coaches have not in the past."

RETURN TEAM TACTICS

Below are some of my favorite return tactics. These tactics include where to hit your return and why, plus what to expect after the return is hit and how to react.

8. The Bread and Butter

What is it? A return low, over the center net strap.

How to execute? Hit the return low over the middle net strap. The returner's partner pinches towards the middle around the service line. If they see the ball get past the opposing net player, they should move forward towards the net.

When to use it? Use this on most return points. This is a great primary tactic because it makes for a difficult low volley for the server's partner and takes away any angles they have.



9. The 2nd Serve Assault

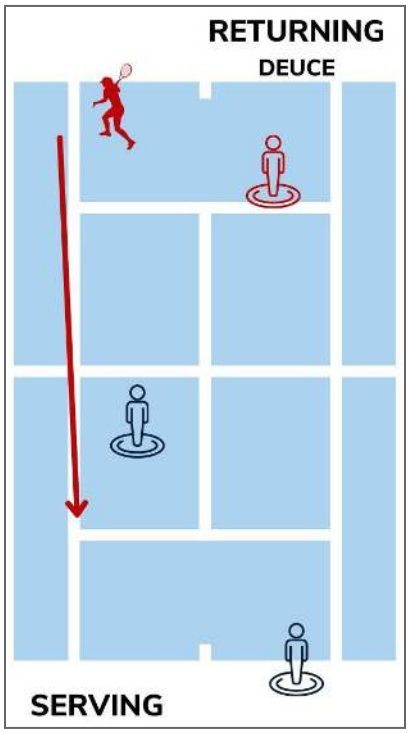
What is it? Against a 2nd serve, run around your backhand and hit a forehand down the line.

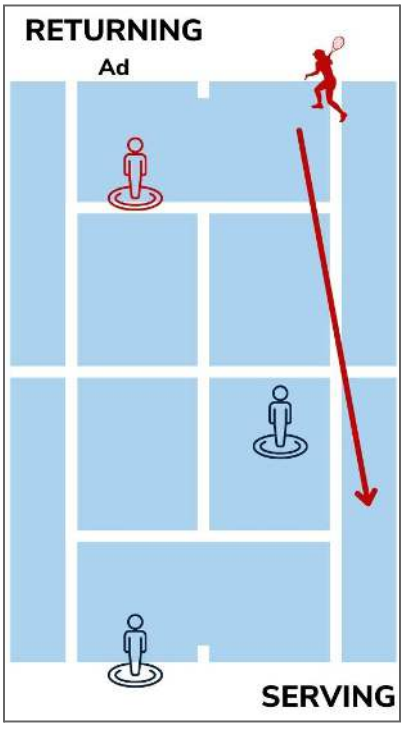
How to execute? When you get a second serve, run around your backhand and hit a forehand. The net player should pinch towards the middle around the service line area to close off the middle.

- **Deuce Court:** Don't go for the winner. Instead, aim for the singles line. This is usually at the net player's backhand volley. Move forward after you hit it because they will likely hit a short volley.

- **Ad Court:** Since the opponent's forehand volley is in the alley, go for the winner. Hit your inside-in forehand hard, aiming for the middle of the doubles alley.

When to use it? This is a secondary tactic. In the deuce court, you can use it a bit more often, around 2-4 times per set in most matches. From the ad side it should be used rarely, no more than 2 times per set. It's a great tactic against aggressive net players to keep them "home".





10. The Called Poach

What is it? A poach by the returner's partner after a crosscourt return to the server.

How to execute? Tell your partner that you'll poach before the point. The returner needs to hit a quality return crosscourt to the server. The net player moves across, close to the net, to volley the next shot. The returner should switch to cover a down the line shot. If the return is weak, call the play off and don't poach.

When to use it? This is a great secondary tactic against weak second serves or on low-risk points. Up or down in the game 40-0 or 40-15. It's also a great tactic against a player who serves and volleys if the returner can hit the ball low at their feet.



11. Return & Volley

What is it? Return back to the server (usually crosscourt), and follow the return into the net.

How to execute? The returner should step forward and try to take the return from inside the baseline. Block the return back towards the server and move forward, applying pressure to the server to come up with a good shot. The returner's partner should pinch the middle based on the quality and placement of the return.

When to use it? When you don't like your matchup from the baseline, or are a better net player. It's also a great tactic to use against second serves.

> *"The key to breaking serve in doubles is making a lot of returns. Generally, the best return target is the center net strap."*
>
> **- *Read More on Return Strategy***

12. Return +1 & Volley

What is it? Return back to the server, then follow your next shot, called the return +1, into the net.

How to execute? Hit your first shot after the return deep and slow/high over the net to buy yourself time to move forward. A low slice works as well. The returner's partner should pinch towards the middle based on the quality and placement of the return +1.

When to use it? When you don't like your matchup from the baseline, but aren't comfortable with a return and volley.

NET PLAY TACTICS

Below are some of my favorite net play tactics. Whether you're comfortable at the net or not, these tactics will help you play the right shot and force errors from the opponents.

13. The Sneak Attack

What is it? Play the ball low and short through the middle of the court and close to the center net strap for a put away volley.

How to execute? Play a low, short slice through the middle. Ideally, your opponent should be hitting the ball from around the service line, or closer. Then you close the middle net strap for a reaction volley since they have to pop the ball up and you've taken away their angles. Your partner will need to cover any lobs.

When to use it? This is great to use when both opponents are already at the net, or you have a volley or transition volley that you can't attack yet from closer to the baseline.



14. The Mid-Rally Poach

What is it? Poach during the rally. Vary your timing of the poach based on the opponents skill level and the quality of the ball your partner has hit.

How to execute? Poach early if the opponent is off-balance or has a backhand from deep in the court to make them redirect and force an error. Poach late if they have a more comfortable shot to surprise them and hit a volley.

When to use it? When your partner is in a crosscourt rally that is a bad matchup.

> *"Too many players wait for a ball to poach on, instead of creating a time to poach for themselves."*
>
> **-** ***Read More Poaching Tips Here***

15. The Mid-Rally Fake

What is it? Fake during the rally to force a redirection or an error from the opponent.

How to execute? During the rally, move towards the center net strap early, as the ball is moving towards the opponent, to fake the poach. Then recover towards the doubles alley for a volley.

When to use it? Anytime your partner is in a crosscourt rally. This is a great tactic in the ad court for right-handed players because you will have a forehand volley if the opponent tries to hit down the line.

16. The Defensive Volley

What is it? Hit any defensive volley, from out of position or below the net, with depth to the back player.

How to execute? On defensive volleys, the goal is to stay in the point. Keep the ball away from the net player and hit with depth, ideally to the opponent's backhand.

When to use it? Anytime you're hitting a volley from below the height of the net, or from an off-balance position.



Bonus Content: The Volley Checklist
Stop missing volleys by checking these 3 keys in your technique

17. The One-More-Shot Volley

What is it? On neutral volleys or even some offensive volleys, try to set up your next shot.

How to execute? Hit your volley to the feet of the opponent's backhand side, then close towards the net in the direction of the ball. They will pop the ball up so you can finish the point.

When to use it? Anytime you're hitting a volley from around the height of the net or from the middle of the service box. It's not yet time to go for the winner.

BASELINE TACTICS

Below are some of my favorite baseline tactics. If you're more of a baseliner, these will help you set up your net player and force errors from the opponents.

18. The Full Court Press

What is it? Pushing the opponent back behind the baseline to apply pressure.

How to execute? Play the ball deep in the court to push the opponent behind the baseline. It's best to play through the middle of the court if you can. This helps set up your net player, but be careful not to hit the ball to the opposing net player.

When to use it? This is a great strategy during any kind of baseline rally. Stay aware of the matchup though. Don't get stuck in a baseline rally with someone who is better at rallying from the baseline.

19. The Slice & Dice

What is it? Using slice and variety to throw the opponent off-balance.

How to execute? Hit a slice to the opponent, varying your direction, depth, and possibly height, although low is typically better. The short slice through the middle is a great shot to get your net player involved.

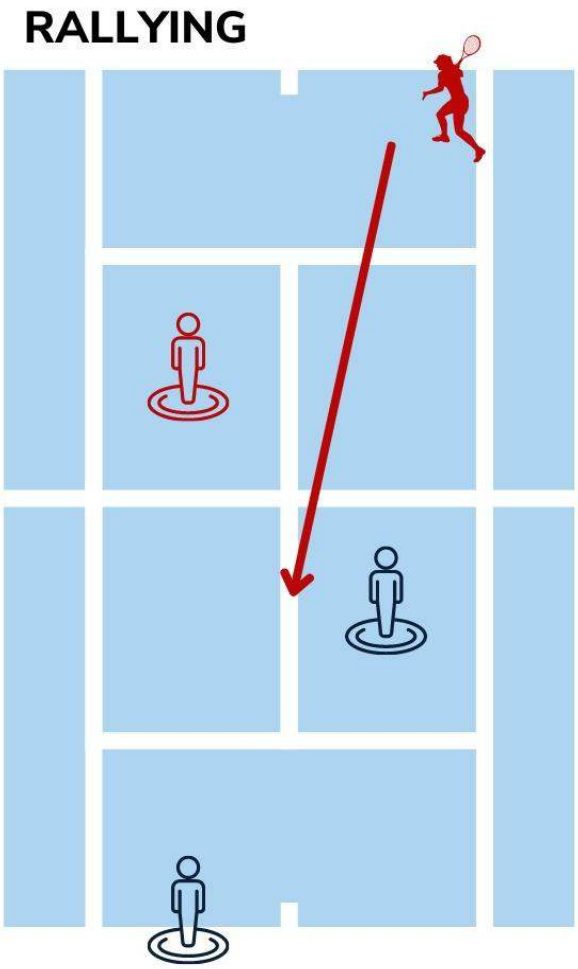
When to use it? This is a great secondary tactic to mix in during baseline rallies. You can often draw an error or get a volley for your net player. It's also great to use against younger high school or college level players since they are so used to hitting topspin from the baseline.

20. Bait the Middle (Ad Court)

What is it? Baiting the opposing net player into a weak backhand volley.

How to execute? This is best hit from the ad court as an inside-out forehand. Play the ball low down the middle of the court, near the opposing net player's backhand volley. The goal is to make them stab at a backhand volley to force an error or have them pop the ball up, setting up your next shot.

When to use it? Anytime you have a forehand from the ad court inside the baseline. This can also be used in the deuce court against left-handed net players.



21. The Backhand Volley Meltdown

What is it? Breaking down the opponent's backhand volleys to force errors.

How to execute? Hit your best groundstroke (usually forehand) at the opponent's backhand volley. Typically a low ball is best, but against most players any groundstroke with good pace will force an error or a weak volley, setting up your next shot.

When to use it? Anytime one of the opposing net player's is weak and you have an on-balance groundstroke from inside the baseline.

APPROACH TACTICS

Below are some of my favorite approach tactics for doubles. When you get a short ball, especially a forehand, use these to win the point.

22. The Shoe Shine

What is it? Hitting a low ball at the shoes of the opponent.

How to execute? When you get a short ball, hit a forehand with topspin down at the opposing net player's feet, preferably to their backhand side. Follow the shot into the net, ready for a ball to be popped up.

When to use it? This is a great primary tactic for approach shots. You will force a lot of errors and get plenty of easy next balls.



23. Bully Mode

What is it? Picking on one opposing player at all costs.

How to execute? Simple, hit every single ball at the weaker opponent, no matter what.

When to use it? This is great to use for leagues where there is a difference in level. For example, in USTA 8.0 mixed doubles, you'll often see a 4.5 playing with a 3.5 player. Bully the 3.5!



Bonus Lesson:
How to Beat the Lob or Pusher in Doubles

24. The Sneaky Lob

What is it? A lob approach shot.

How to execute? As you approach the ball, hit a lob down the line over the opposing net player. Keep the ball as low as possible without giving them an overhead.

When to use it? This is a good tactic against aggressive net players. It's best executed when you have a low short ball that you need to come forward on. You can also use it when you're stuck in a crosscourt rally that you don't like.

25. Middle Blitz

What is it? A full blitz through the middle of the court.

How to execute? Hit the ball right down the middle, low over the center net strap. Then follow your approach shot in towards the middle to volley the next ball. Your partner should also pinch towards the middle.

When to use it? This is a great primary tactic for approaching. Taking over the middle net strap area is important in doubles, and this is one of the best ways to do it.



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- The 3 Principles of Winning Tennis
- Guide to Improve Your Mental Toughness
- The #1 Thing to Add to Your Tennis Game

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